

Asakusa & Ryogoku, Tokyo

Then-and-now aerial photographs, how the ground was made, and the disasters people chose to remember — compiled automatically from public Japanese government data.



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Study area	2.6 km × 1.7 km around 35.7050° N, 139.7975° E
Oldest aerial photograph	c. 1936–1942
Aerial series in this brief	c. 1936–1942, 1945–1950, 1961–1969, 1974–1978, 1979–1983, 1984–1986, 1987–1990, 2019
Main natural landform	Former water area (38%)
Former river channels	none mapped
Filled, reclaimed or drained land	91%
Former sea, river or pond	38%
Meiji-era paddies, marsh and flats	rice paddy 3.9%, thatch-grass fields 0.7%
Disaster memorials within 3 km	15 (earthquake 13, other 2, volcanic disaster 2)

What this brief is. A reading aid for comparing the same ground across decades. It shows what the photographs and GSI's land surveys record; it does not describe current conditions, access or opening hours.

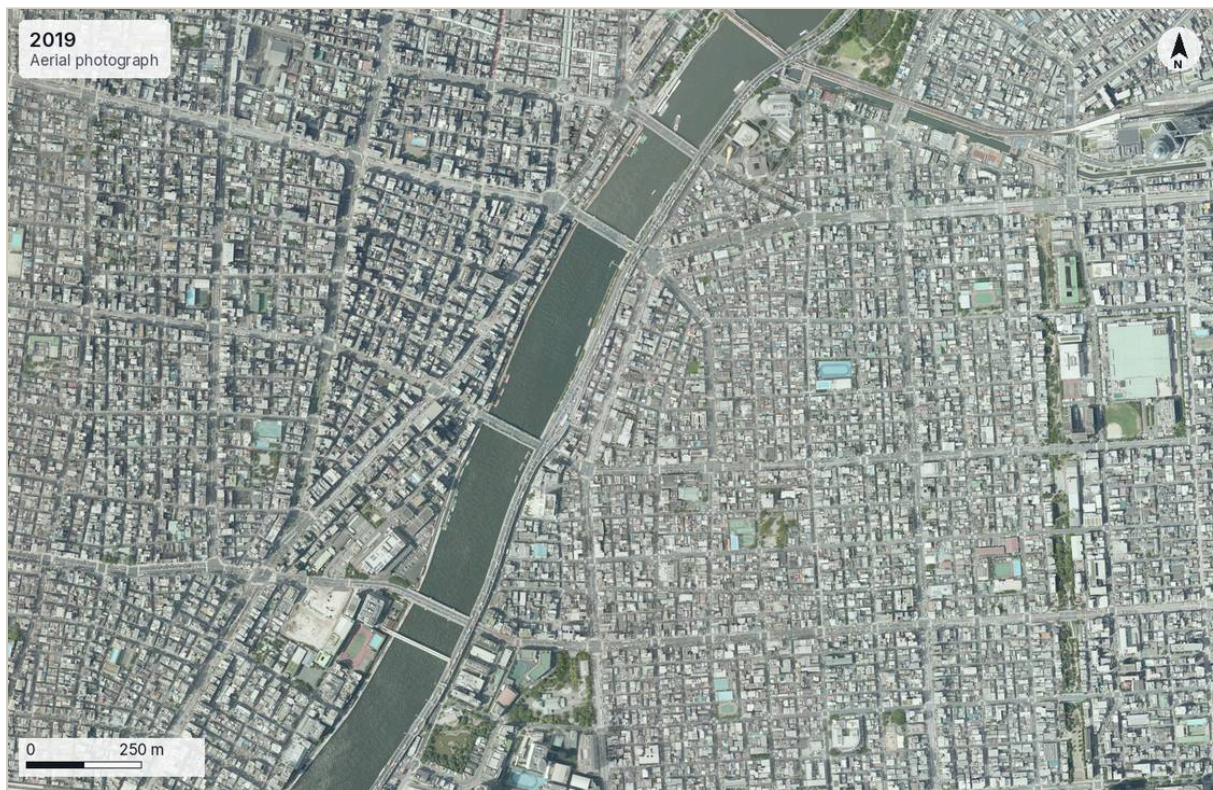
What it is not. Not a hazard assessment or a property survey. Landform classes describe typical tendencies of the ground; for present-day risk, read the official hazard map of the municipality.

Edition 2026-09-27. Aerial photographs, landform and Meiji-era lowland data: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), processed by Japan Time Atlas. Memorial data: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials, summarised and translated by Japan Time Atlas.

The same ground, c. 1936–1942 and 2019



c. 1936–1942 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_riku10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

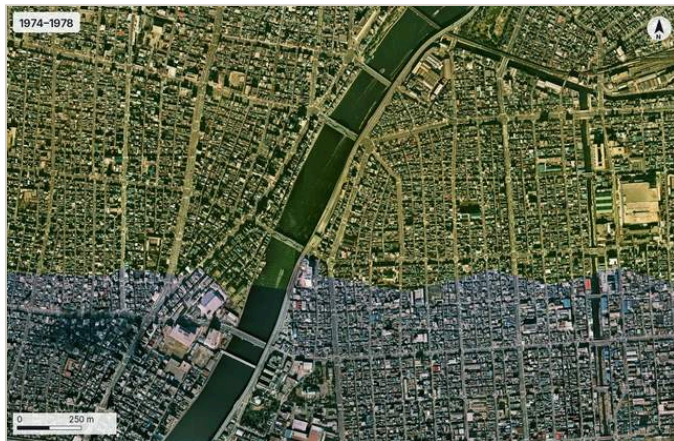
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1945–1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



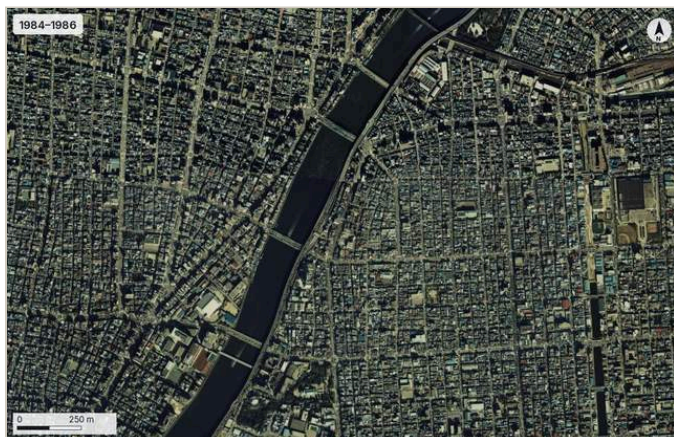
1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



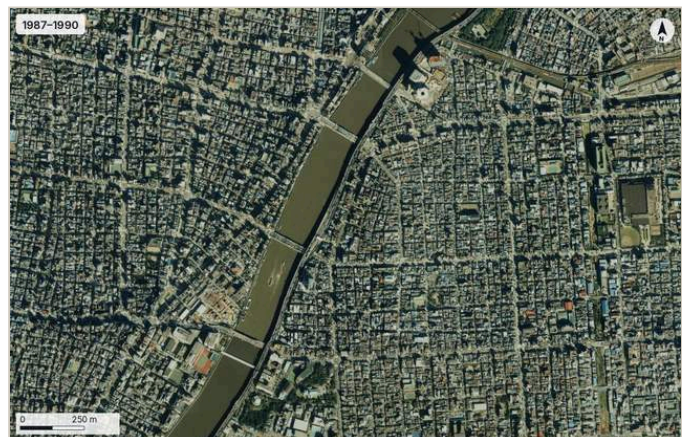
1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed

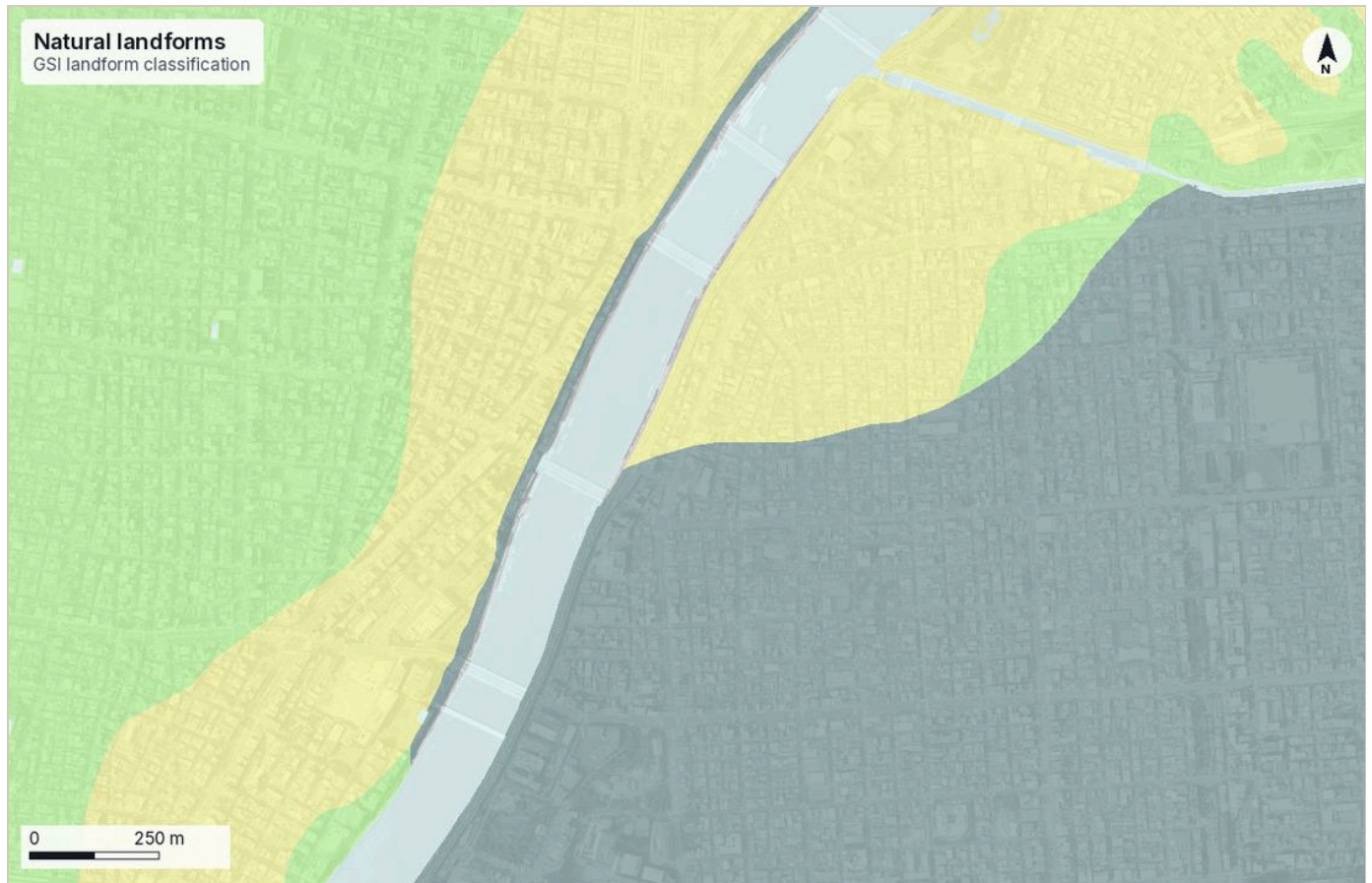


1984–1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed



1987–1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.



What the main landforms mean

Former water area (38%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Sandbars and dunes (28%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Floodplain and coastal plain (27%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

 Filled and reclaimed land 91%

Meiji-era lowland

 River, pond or sea 11%

 Rice paddy 3.9%

 Thatch-grass fields 0.7%

Filled and reclaimed land (91%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the Ishiware-cho victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire 大正大震災火災石原町遭難者碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1925	0.6 km
2	Memorial to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire 大震災遭難者追悼之碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1931	0.9 km
3	Stone Jizo statue for the Tatekawa riverbank victims of the 1923 earthquake fire 大震災堅川岸遭難者追善石造地藏菩薩立像	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1924	1.4 km
4	Grave of those killed in the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 大震災横死者之墓(関東大地震横死者供養碑)	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	unknown	1.4 km
5	Memorial to those crushed to death in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake 安政江戸地震圧死者供養塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) · earthquake	1856	1.4 km
6	Memorial to those killed in the two Ansei disasters of 1855 and 1856 安政二年・三年両度天災横死諸靈魂追善供養塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) and Ansei Edo typhoon (23 Sep 1856) · earthquake / other	1857	1.4 km
7	Memorial to all who died in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake and its fires 地震焼亡横死諸群靈塔	Ansei Edo earthquake (11 Nov 1855) · earthquake	1866	1.4 km
8	Memorial to the victims of the 1783 Mount Asama eruption in Shinshu and Joshu 天明三年癸卯七月七日八日信州上州地変横死之諸靈魂等供養塔	Tenmei eruption of Mount Asama (4 Aug 1783) · volcanic disaster	1785	1.4 km
9	Memorial to those killed in the disasters since the 1783 Mount Asama eruption 信州浅間山噴火以来天災横死者供養塔	Tenmei eruption of Mount Asama (4 Aug 1783) and later disasters · volcanic disaster / other	1789	1.4 km
10	Memorial to Aioi Police Station officers who died on duty in the 1923 earthquake fire 大震災相生警察署員殉職之碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1933	1.6 km
11	Monument to the neighborhood defended from fire in 1923 防火守護地の碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1968	1.8 km
12	Memorial to those who found refuge at Shin-Ohashi Bridge in 1923 避難記念	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1933	2.1 km

What the memorials record

- 1. Memorial to the Ishiwara-cho victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire.** The fires that followed the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 reduced most of the city to ashes; Honjo and Fukagawa wards suffered worst, and countless lives were lost. Of about 8,000 residents of Ishiwara-cho in Honjo Ward, about 7,000 burned to death. The stone was relocated in 1931.
- 2. Memorial to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake fire.** The Honjo area suffered enormous damage in the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923. A memorial to the victims was erected in March 1931; because it was damaged during the air raid on Tokyo of 10 March 1945, the present stone was rebuilt in 1961.
- 3. Stone Jizo statue for the Tatekawa riverbank victims of the 1923 earthquake fire.** On the afternoon of 1 September 1923, the day of the Great Kanto Earthquake, several hundred people on the Tatekawa riverbank, trapped by black smoke and fierce flames, threw themselves into the river, and many drowned; many others burned to death. The Jizo was erected in November 1924, and its base inscription dedicates it to these victims.
- 4. Grave of those killed in the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake.** Probably erected for victims of the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 in the Ryogoku police district. Its inscriptions give the date, "ninety-odd" dead and the donor, the Aioi Barbers' Association, and record a gift of 50 yen to the temple for memorial services.
- 5. Memorial to those crushed to death in the 1855 Ansei Edo earthquake.** Around 10 pm on 11 November 1855 a great earthquake struck Edo, and tens of thousands of people were crushed or burned to death. According to the inscription, a group of plasterers from Azabu planned this memorial to ease the victims' suffering, and the high priest of Zojoji, praising their aim, wrote the invocation "Namu Amida Butsu" for it.
- 6. Memorial to those killed in the two Ansei disasters of 1855 and 1856.** The Ansei Edo earthquake of 11 November 1855 brought down houses and storehouses and started fires in dozens of places; on 23 September 1856 a typhoon flattened houses and riverside floods swept others away. Many were crushed, burned or drowned. Carved with six Jizo figures, the memorial was set up in 1857 for the dead of both disasters.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Where every element comes from

- **Aerial photographs** (pp. 2–3) — Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), GSI Tiles: series *ort_riku10* (c. 1936–1942), *ort_USA10* (1945–1950, US military photography), *ort_old10* (1961–1969), *gazo1* (1974–1978), *gazo2* (1979–1983), *gazo3* (1984–1986), *gazo4* (1987–1990) and *nendophoto2019*. Cropped, resized and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. List of GSI Tiles: <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>
- **Landform classification** (pp. 4–5) — GSI landform-classification vector tiles (natural and artificial landforms), compiled by GSI from its Land Condition Maps, Flood Control Terrain Classification Maps and vulnerable-landform surveys. Rendered, measured and translated into English by Japan Time Atlas. https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification
- **Meiji-era lowland** (p. 5) — GSI “明治期の低湿地” tiles and legend (https://maps.gsi.go.jp/legend/lw_legend.pdf), measured and translated by Japan Time Atlas.
- **Natural disaster memorials** (p. 6) — GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑), registered by municipalities, <https://www.gsi.go.jp/bousaichiri/denshouhi.html>; processed by Japan Time Atlas (selection by distance, English translation and summary). Memorial photographs are not reproduced.
- GSI content is used under the GSI Content Terms of Use, which follow the Public Data License v1.0 (PDL1.0, compatible with CC BY 4.0). Data retrieved 2026-09-27.
- **Outline of Japan** — Data of Japan / JapanPrefGeoJson (public domain), simplified.

Method

The study area is a fixed rectangle of 2.6 × 1.7 km. Every GSI photo series that covers at least 85% of it is included; the newest annual orthophoto covering at least 90% of it is used as “now”, with any gap filled from GSI's latest seamless mosaic. Landform shares are areas of the rectangle measured on GSI's polygons at zoom level 14, each class merged before measuring. Meiji-era shares count map pixels by legend color. Memorials are selected by straight-line distance from the center of the study area.

Limits

Historical series are mosaics of photographs taken on different dates; GSI publishes the flight date of each photograph. Landform data record conditions at the time of survey. Nothing in this brief shows present-day access, safety or opening hours.

Area Dossier. The same district with a 4–8 page English history, written from Japanese library sources and cited page by page.

Deep Research. A single hamlet or address, researched in libraries and archives.

Compiled by Japan Time Atlas; not produced, reviewed or endorsed by GSI, MLIT or any Japanese government agency. Not an official hazard map and not for statutory real-estate disclosure. Generated 2026-09-27 by an automated pipeline (research/lab-07/scripts/basic.py).